Running Home (to your sweet nothings)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/47119474.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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High School AU, Some Fluff, some temporary sad, Happy Ending, Catra is a musician, adora is a jock, Glimmer just really wants to be a good friend okay, they're all seventeen and stupid it's fine, Secret Admirer, Pining, so much pining

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by catrasredemption (dimensionhoppingrose)

Summary

"We should try to figure it out," Glimmer said, punching her fist against her open palm. "It's our *senior year*. We're never going to get another chance if we don't find out who it is *now*!"

"Or," Bow said helpfully, "we could just let Adora have this thing that clearly makes her happy."

"But Adora wants to know too! Don't you?" Glimmer asked, rounding on Adora.

"Um." The truth was, Adora wasn't sure. She liked the illusion she had now, where her secret admirer was someone sensitive and caring and pretty and cared enough to *continue* crafting elegant letters for her even after entire summers apart. Was that weird?

Secret Admirer/High School AU

Notes

This is one I've been toying with for awhile, so... be kind.

See the end of the work for more notes

"Oooooh, Adora's secret admirer is back."

Adora blushed, slipping the envelope into her bag. It wasn't that she was embarrassed – these letters were the highlight of her day sometimes. A reminder that someone truly cared about her. Someone who had been hovering in the shadows for the last three years, persisting through two summer vacations and winter breaks. The plain envelopes with her name scrawled across them in a beautiful script had become treasures that she looked forward to every day.

"Aren't you going to read it?" Bow asked curiously.

"Later." She'd learned not to read them in front of her friends. Or anyone. They were really sweet letters, honestly. Beautifully composed with what Bow had guessed was a fountain pen. Nothing even remotely inappropriate. Sometimes there were poems. Or song lyrics, maybe – the letter writer had told her once that she wrote music. Sometimes Adora tried to sing the poems, but she couldn't carry a tone in a bucket (according to her loving aunt, who was just as tone deaf), so she just hummed to herself as she read. They felt like something beautiful and private, not to be shared with anyone else. Not even Bow and Glimmer, who knew her better than anyone else.

It had been three years since Adora had started receiving these letters. The first one had been short and shy, written by an obviously awkward fourteen year old who had a crush and didn't know how to handle it.

I wish I knew how to talk to you.

At first, Glimmer had thought maybe it was a weird stalker situation, and had cautioned Adora about getting too close, or accepting any invitations from the letter writer. But the writer had never even hinted about wanting to meet Adora. In fact, she (or at least, Adora hoped it was a she) had been almost militant about keeping her identity a

secret. Even the ones that complimented her looks or said things like *You looked really pretty yesterday* never felt weird or off. The poems or song lyrics were always Adora's favorite letters, though. Not because she found the other letters creepy – the poems were just always so cute and sweet.

"Don't you think this is kind of ridiculous?" Glimmer asked as they walked down the hall. "I mean, it's been *three years*. Who spends *three years* pining for someone?"

"You'd be surprised," Bow said. "My dads were friends for six years before they started dating."

"So, gay people. Got it."

Bow coughed while Adora blushed furiously. It wasn't like it was *uncommon knowledge* that she was a lesbian. Even if she hadn't dated much, or at all, she played *football*. She had her fair share of female admirers (not to brag or anything). Glimmer had suggested once that it might be one of her fangirls leaving the notes to try and look cute.

But that just wasn't the feeling Adora got from this. It felt like someone who *knew* her. Which should have been weird, right? Adora couldn't pinpoint why exactly she trusted this random person who left letters in her locker. It was totally one-sided, and by all rights it should have been weird. Maybe Adora was just too naive.

"We should try to figure it out," Glimmer said, punching her fist against her open palm. "It's our *senior year*. We're never going to get another chance if we don't find out who it is *now*!"

"Or," Bow said helpfully, "we could just let Adora have this thing that clearly makes her happy."

"But Adora wants to know too! Don't you?" Glimmer asked, rounding on Adora.

"Um." The truth was, Adora wasn't sure. She liked the illusion she had now, where her secret admirer was someone sensitive and caring and pretty and cared enough to *continue* crafting elegant letters for her even after entire summers apart. Was that weird?

The bell rang, jarring Adora out of her musings. "Meeting at lunch," Glimmer declared, hooking her bag over her shoulder. "See you guys later!"

Adora spent most of the morning daydreaming her way through class and wondering about the letter in her bag. She couldn't imagine the writer being anything but wonderful and kind. Someone who knew her, clearly.

It was a silly, slightly childish dream. She wasn't living in a story. There was no happily ever after waiting for her with the letter writer. They'd graduate high school without her ever finding the person, and she would move on, maybe find a nice girl in college or after school and settle down. Or maybe she wouldn't. Either way, the letter writer probably wasn't her endgame.

But she still wanted to *know*. She wanted to thank the letter writer, if nothing else. She'd always seemed to know when Adora needed kind words—after a failed test, or losing a game, or a bad practice. She could always look forward to encouragement waiting for her in her locker. The idea made her feel giddy.

Glimmer was bouncing and ready to go with her notebook as soon as Adora joined them at the usual lunch table.

"Okay!" she said, bouncing. "So I went through every girl in our grade—"

"When did you do this?" Bow asked, raising an eyebrow.

"During Calculus. I ruled out all the confirmed straight people, then everyone who's already dating someone, and that left me with eight

people—Perfuma, Scorpia, Huntara, Teela, Lynn, Tallstar, and Arvela."

"You have Mermista too," Bow pointed out.

"With a question mark. I'm not sure if she's dating Sea Hawk or not."

"I don't think they know, either."

Adora eyed the list, going over the names. There was a glaring absence, though. "You forgot someone."

"What?" Glimmer asked in disbelief, scanning her list. "Who?"

"Catra Bluth."

Glimmer made a show of rolling her eyes and groaning loudly. "She's not *capable* of caring about anyone but herself. There's an element of believability here."

Glimmer was completely wrong about that—Catra had been Adora's friend for years, and Catra cared about *everyone* more than herself. But she likely wasn't the type to write soft, warm love letters under the guise of secrecy for three years. If she had feelings for Adora, she could just *tell* her. Adora would readily admit that Catra had been her gay awakening, and part of that crush had lingered over the years. But it was just that—a crush that would never evolve any further. Even if Adora wished it would.

"Any names standing out to you?" Glimmer prompted, bringing Adora back to reality. She looked at the list again, frowning. She had a type, and it was definitely big, muscular women. Scorpia and Huntara fit that bill pretty well. But she couldn't imagine either of them writing love letters to her. Scorpia wasn't exactly *subtle*, and Huntara didn't seem like she would care enough for that.

"Arvella just transferred here at the end of last year," Bow pointed out. "The letters started before that."

"Oh, good point." Glimmer crossed that name out.

"Isn't Lynn the witchy girl?"

"Pagan."

"Right. She seems more like the 'well lie together in our graves for all of eternity' poetry type." Bow looked at Adora. "Do you get those vibes from the letters?"

"Definitely not."

Glimmer wrote *probably not* next to Lynn. "Perfuma seems like the kind of person who would write love letters," Adora said after a moment. She did *not* want it to be Perfuma, but they had to explore all possibilities.

"Perfuma is also the kind of person who goes for what she wants, though," Bow pointed out. Glimmer scowled deeply. The ninth-grade Winter Fest Dance incident would be an event that went down in infamy. "Pining for this long doesn't really seem like her thing."

"She's too hippy-ish for you anyway," Glimmer declared, crossing Perfuma's name off. "So that leaves Scorpia, Huntara, Teela, and Tallstar."

"I really don't think it would be Scorpia or Huntara," Adora admitted. "But I guess I can't completely rule it out, either. Also, add Perfuma back to the list."

"What?" Glimmer asked in disbelief. "Do you *actually*—"

"No! But if we're looking at every single possibility, she *is* a valid option."

Glimmer sighed and wrote Perfuma's name at the bottom of the list. "So Scorpia, Huntara, Teela, Tallstar, and Perfuma. Anyone in particular standing out to you?"

Not really ,"Adora said. They were all perfectly nice people and very attractive, but Adora couldn't honestly say she'd ever felt more than a passing *oh she's cute* for any of them. But if one of them turned out to be the letter writer, would it change things? She looked around the cafeteria, her eyes finding Scorpia first. She was sitting at another table with Entrapta and Catra, talking animatedly while Entrapta worked on something and Catra presumably did homework. She was always working on something. Not that Adora spent a lot of time watching her or anything.

She *knew* who she wanted the letter writer to be. Would it be unfair to the person if she had expectations and they were wrong? Was she just setting them both up for disappointment?

Adora didn't get a chance to read the letter until she got home from football practice. She carefully opened the envelope and slid the piece of paper out. It felt different—a little thicker, a little more textured—than regular paper. Did this person have special paper that she used just to write letters? The thought made Adora's heart swell. She was smiling before she even started reading.

You know, I really hate Taylor Swift. Like, sometimes the sound of her songs makes me want to shove pencils in my ears. But I found this really nice cover on YouTube of probably her worst song and it made me think of you when I heard it. I've been trying to rework it so I can sing it myself, but there's some kind of block I guess I have to get over the Taylor Swift hate.

PS Sorry if you like Taylor Swift but your taste in music sucks.

Adora read through the letter, trying not to laugh. She didn't care much about Taylor Swift, but she knew Glimmer was a fan. Five lines from the song were written at the bottom:

Baby, just take me

somewhere we can be alone

I'm waiting all that's left to do is run

We'll go far away and we'll make it out of this mess

It's a brave story, babe, just say yes

Huh. It was true, making a song gay made it automatically so much better. Adora read the lyrics over and over. She didn't know enough about Taylor Swift to guess the song this was based on. Glimmer might, but Adora didn't like sharing the letters. They were so personal—something meant for her eyes only. It felt wrong to show someone else. And Adora *wanted* to keep them to herself. They were for her and no one else. Was it selfish? Maybe. Was she okay with that? Yes.

Maybe she *had* to find the letter writer. Even if she didn't feel anything for the other person, she wanted to at least acknowledge them, and tell them how much the letters meant. How loved they made her feel. Maybe nothing would come of it, but she felt like she at least owed the person that much.

Adora found herself paying attention to *everyone* the next day. She spotted Tallstar in homeroom—the other girl gave her a smile when she saw Adora looking, and Adora waved back awkwardly before taking her seat.

Perfuma was in her nature science class. She sat at the table in front of Adora, and spent most of the period trying to get Entrapta to pay attention. It wasn't that Entrapta wasn't smart—it was just that she had deemed everything *not* related to science and specifically robotics not worth her time, which meant her other grades suffered. Perfuma tried to be patient, but easily grew exasperated and eventually gave up when Entrapta snuck out whatever she was taking apart for the fifth time.

She saw Huntara at lunch, eating with her usual group of soccer friends. She was tall and white-haired and...well, *bit*, to put it

simply. Adora would be lying if she said she didn't find the muscles a little attractive. Glimmer had joked once that she seemed to have a thing for muscular woman. Weird how only three had made the final cut.

Teela was in English, Adora's last class of the day. The idea of *her* being the letter writer made Adora feel a little weird – they'd been neighbors for most of their lives, until Teela's family moved across town a couple years ago. If Teela had any actual feelings for her, Adora felt like she would have said something already. They knew each other, after all. It wasn't that hard.

Scorpia was at football practice, chattering away as usual, greeting Adora with a cheery wave when she walked out onto the field with everyone else. They stopped to talk strategy for a few minutes before the coach blew the whistle and gathered them all up to run drills.

Bow and Glimmer were waiting after football practice to take Adora out for ice cream. "Any thoughts?" Glimmer asked as soon as they had their treats and were settled at the table. Bow gave her a stern look.

"You said you weren't going to bring it up."

"But this is important! Adora's social life is on the line!"

It wasn't *that* dire, Adora thought, pouting. "I dunno." She licked her ice cream before it could start melting. "They're all great, don't get me wrong, just…"

"Not your type?" Bow guessed. Adora shrugged. "What *are* you looking for in a girl? I mean, who would your ideal girl be?"

That was a big question. Adora frowned, staring at her ice cream like maybe it would have the answers. "I guess… someone who feels like they can talk to me. Someone I can share things with, and they can share things with me."

"Okay , yeah," Glimmer said. "But those are really generic things."

"What Glimmer means is that those are things everyone wants," Bow said quickly . "But there are things *you* want as well. Or you're allowed to want them, anyway."

Adora frowned, thinking. She found muscular women attractive, but the idea of dating someone artistic made her feel warm. Was that because of the letter writer? Did she have too many expectations? What if she ruined things?

"I don't know," she said, because that was safer than voicing her fears. "I think I want the letter writer."

"Then we have to figure out who it is," Glimmer said, clapping her hands together. "We've got a list. We'll just work our way through it. Oooooooooh, you should ask her to the Winter Fest Dance when you find her! I bet you'd be a cute couple."

"Let's not get too ahead of ourselves." Bow was ever the pragmatist. "Focus on finding her first, then figure out if she's really someone you want to date."

"Would figuring out who she is really change how you feel, though?" Glimmer pushed. Adora wanted to say no, that she just wanted to be with the letter writer. But at the same time there were people she just couldn't see herself dating. Why did everything have to be so complicated?

Adora set things into motion the next morning, taking a chance to approach each of the girls when she could. She sat next to Tallstar in Homeroom — the conversation was a bit awkward, but pleasant.

She asked Perfuma for help identifying plants during class, something Perfuma was more than happy to assist with, and they talked animatedly for a bit before Entrapta distracted Perfuma again.

Huntara wasn't in any of her classes so she couldn't pin her down, but the more she thought about it, the more she really doubted it was Huntara. She just didn't fit.

She talked to Teela before English, and they ended up making plans to go out and catch up. Teela wasn't shy. If she wanted to go out with Adora, she'd just ask, wouldn't she?

And finally, she talked to Scorpia for a bit after practice. They mostly talked about how it had gone, and the upcoming game, but it was something. Adora *also* noticed Perfuma waiting with Entrapta, though, and Scorpia seemed eager to go over and talk to her. Hmn. Adora was so distracted watching them that she didn't realize she was about to walk into someone until—

"Oof!"

Adora stumbled back and yelped, automatically reaching to grab the person. "Sorry! I'm so…"

Her voice drifted off. It was Catra. The other girl looked a little irritated, but her expression softened somewhat when she saw Adora. "Hey, Adora. It's fine."

She stooped down to pick up the notebooks she'd dropped. "Is practice over? Scorpia was supposed to meet me like five minutes ago to get these notes."

"Oh, she's…" Adora gestured vaguely behind her. Catra leaned around to look, snorted, and rolled her eyes.

"If one of them doesn't make a move soon I'm going to lose my damn mind."

Adora looked at her, blinking. "What—Scorpia and Perfuma?"

"Yeah. They worked together over the summer and Scorpia's been obsessed for *months*. And Perfuma's definitely not subtle, but

Scorpia literally cant take a hint. It's driving me insane."

"Oh," Adora said dumbly. Catra raised an eyebrow.

"What? You been pining after Scorpia?"

"No!" Adora said quickly. "I dont think she's my type."

"Really? Isnt big and muscular your type?"

Wow. Adora really did have a reputation. "Catra!" Scorpia called, waving. Catra shrugged, giving Adora a small, almost non-existent smile, and went to meet her friends. Adora watched her go, feeling a pang in her chest. She had never *really* gotten over her crush on Catra. She was fine, she didnt constantly pine after Catra or anything, but...if she wanted the letter writer to be anyone, it would definitely be Catra.

But even she knew that was impossible.

"How do you know if a girl likes you?"

Mara looked up from her plate, a little surprised. Adora didnt ask things like that often. "I just kind of brought Hope home and let her stay."

"You make me sound like a stray cat," Hope said dryly. Adora gave them both an indulgent smile. "Why do you ask, Adora?"

Adora shrugged, looking at her plate. "Just...curious. There's a girl I think might like me." She hated herself already for bringing this up. She was so bad at talking. "But...I...dont know. It's hard."

Adora had never actually come out to her aunts—they'd all just quietly accepted she was a lesbian, and enjoyed playing the "who's cuter" game when they watched TV or movies together. Mara had

declared that *her* taste in women was the best, and that Hope and Adora were hopeless. Adora tended to ignore her.

"So should I just bring her home and see what happens?" Adora prompted after a moment. Mara chuckled while Hope rolled her eyes.

"I truly hope you inherited a better sense of romance than your aunt has."

"Rude," Mara huffed. "Okay Ms. *Queen* of Romance, how could you tell that I liked you?"

"You tripped over yourself trying to give me flowers."

Mara blushed. Adora laughed. Yeah, that sounded like Mara. Well meaning, but two left feet. Wait. Was that also Adora?

"Is it that friend of yours – Catra?" Mara asked, changing the subject. Adora felt like all the blood in her body rushed to her face.

"No!" Mara and Hope raised their eyebrows. "It's… *not*. I kind of had a crush on her when we were younger, but she doesn't… we're not really friends."

"That's a shame," Hope said thoughtfully. "I work with her mother, you know. She's apparently on track for early acceptance into Harvard."

That wasn't really surprising. Catra had always been too smart for her own good. It used to make Adora a little jealous. She *wasn't* good at school, and had dyslexia just to pile on top of that. Catra had always helped her when they were in classes together. A small, somewhat bitter part of her wondered if Catra had started ignoring her because she wasn't smart enough. But Scorpia wasn't exactly a genius either, and Catra was fine with her.

So what had Adora done wrong?

"Well, if you're really sure it's not Catra, but you still have feelings for her, then try to let the other girl down gently," Mara said. "It's not worth it to lead her on."

"I wouldn't," Adora said quickly. That was exactly what she was trying to avoid. Whoever her secret admirer was, it would *not* be Catra, and if Adora really didn't feel anything for her, then... well, that was okay. But she still wanted to know. And to figure out how to let the person down easy. Or maybe she *could* develop feelings for her. It wasn't outside the realm of impossibility.

A new note was waiting for Adora the next day.

I think recently that we're really going to go on a date soon. You're going to go off to college or work or something and leave, and maybe forget all about me. And that shouldn't make me feel a little sad, and it does, don't get me wrong. But I've been writing you these letters for years, and don't know how else to communicate, and maybe it's better that way? I know you'll never feel the same way I do. So maybe a clean break is for the best.

Adora read the note a couple of times in a bathroom stall between classes. Her heart felt like it was sinking. Did her secret admirer really think she couldn't possibly have the same feelings? But then why keep writing letters? Adora wished they could talk somehow. Maybe they could figure things out together.

"So it's gotta be Tallstar. Perfect. You have some time to build a relationship with her before you ask her to the dance."

Adora looked around the cafeteria, eyes skipping over Tallstar twice and trying to settle on Catra once before finally finding Tallstar. "You'd like her," Bow said slowly. "Right?"

"Yeah," Adora said. "I mean, I don't know if I like her like that, but I'm sure if I got to know her"...

"You can't force yourself to have feelings for someone."

"But you *do* have feelings for her," Glimmer pushed. "I mean, you care about the letter writer, right? And if Tallstar is the letter writer, then"…

"Yeah," Adora said again. She would just get to know Tallstar. The other girl seemed perfectly nice. It would be fine.

She sat with Tallstar again the next morning, and all through the week. Tallstar even invited her to eat lunch with her and her sister. Adora enjoyed it, she really did, she just didn't feel the spark. But she also didn't get a letter that week, so she had to be on the right track, right? She was talking to the letter writer and proving she really did have feelings for her. Part of her wanted to bring it up, but everything was kind of tenuous, and she didn't want to embarrass Tallstar. They'd get there eventually. There was no rush.

"I so failed," Glimmer groaned, forehead resting on her locker. Bow patted her back.

"I'm sure you didn't," Adora said, trying to be encouraging. She wasn't sure it worked. Midterms were always a bit of an ego blow. Adora was mostly sure she'd passed everything. At least, she hoped she did. Her ability to play football was on the line. Speaking of which, "I… have to get to practice. Try not to stress too much about it."

"Too late."

Practice went well. Adora changed after, said goodbye to her teammates, and made her way back out to the field, planning to cut behind the bleachers to get to the parking lot faster. She paused when she heard… music? Coming from under the bleachers.

"*It's the last thing you wanted, it's the first thing I did. I tell you that I think I'll be back in love with you…*"

Adora frowned, stepping closer until she saw the mysterious musician—Catra, with a guitar. She looked almost peaceful as she strummed away, humming to the tune. Adora hesitated before clearing her throat. Catra jumped, looking back at her.

"Hey! Sorry." Adora held up her hands quickly. "I, um, didn't know you played."

Catra hesitated, looking down at her guitar. "Started a couple years ago. Is practice over? I told Scorpia I'd drive her home."

"Yeah, but she was talking to someone, so it might be awhile."

Catra groaned, letting her head fall back. "Of *course*."

Part of Adora felt like she should leave. But she was so curious. "What were you playing?"

"Just a song." Very descriptive. "I've been trying to practice it, but I'm not very good at it."

She'd sounded great, Adora thought. But Adora didn't know much about music. "Well, play me something you're good at."

"Do I look like I'm taking requests?" There was no bite in her voice, though. She sounded truly amused. It made Adora smile.

"Technically *you're* picking the song. I'm just asking you to play."

Catra looked at her for a long moment, then back at her guitar. If Adora didn't know any better, she'd swear Catra was *blushing*. "Okay, but you can't laugh."

Adora bounced over to sit with her, grinning. "I won't. Promise."

She waited while Catra prepared herself. She took a deep breath, played a few chords, and started singing.

"*We were both young when I first saw you…*"

It sounded vaguely familiar. Adora couldn't place it, but she loved it the minute Catra started singing. She felt enraptured as she watched Catra's fingers move along the guitar strings, and she could have sworn there was an almost *peaceful* look on Catra's face. Catra *never* looked like that. It made something in Adora's chest warm.

"*I'll admit, I don't know. But we were meant to be but no one else agrees, but I don't care about them because you're all I need.*" Adora was crying *on the staircase begin* "*you please don't go.*" and said

The moment was shattered by the thud of something hitting the ground. Catra stopped abruptly, looking past Adora, surprised. Adora looked over her shoulder, and saw Scorpia trying to scoop up her books. "Sorry! Don't mind me. You sound great, Wildcat."

"Thanks." Catra sighed, reaching for her case. "Show's over. You ready to go?"

Scorpia shot Adora an apologetic look that she didn't quite understand. "Yeah. Let's go."

"Cool." Catra stood, hoisting her guitar over her shoulder. "See you around, Adora."

"Yeah." Adora tried to ignore the disappointment and slight resentment toward Scorpia for interrupting. "See you."

"So have you asked her out yet?"

Adora sighed, resting her cheek in her hand as she poked at her lunch. "No."

"Well do you *plan* to ask her out?"

"Glimmer."

"What?" Glimmer looked at Bow, pouting. "We did all this work, she should at least *try*."

Adora kept her eyes on her food, not responding. She knew Glimmer was just trying to be a good friend, but she needed a break from all of this. Did she like Tallstar? Maybe. Did she want to ask her out? Not really. She had no idea how to tell her, though. It felt like she was letting her down. But Adora knew she wasn't in the right head space to date.

Glimmer, thankfully, was already moving on. "Oh, you will not *believe* what the guidance counselor said to me during our meeting. She said I need a tutor for Calculus."

"You do," Bow pointed out.

"I *know*, but then she recommended I ask *Catra*. Catra! Can you believe it? Because *Catra* took the class two years ago and she had the highest grade in the entire school and *blah blah blah*, I get it, Catra is soooooo smart. That doesn't mean I need her to *tutor* me! She'd probably be insufferable."

Adora wasn't *entirely* sure why Glimmer and Catra didn't like each other. They'd been in a group project together Freshman year, and Glimmer had complained the entire time about how much Catra was showing off—which did *not* seem like the Catra that Adora knew, but she never got the other girl's side of the story, since Catra had started distancing herself right after the project ended.

It was Friday, and Adora was looking forward to escaping school as fast as possible. But Tallstar caught her at her locker before she could open it.

"Hey, are you busy this weekend?"

Adora's breath caught, leaving her to stare stupidly at Tallstar for a few seconds. "Um, no. Why?"

"Well I was wondering if you maybe wanted to...do something. It's probably going to be one of the last nice weekends of the year. We could get ice cream or something."

It was a date. Even Adora wasn't oblivious enough to think anything else. Tallstar was asking her out on a date. She turned back to her locker to distract herself, fiddling to get it open. And an envelope fell out, landing neatly face up on the floor. Her name was written across it in familiar calligraphy.

"Oh *wow*, that's so pretty," Tallstar said as she swooped down to pick it up. "Did you do this yourself? I'm so jealous. I watch *so* many calligraphy videos on YouTube, but I could never do it. Do you have fountain pens?"

She handed the envelope back to Adora, eyes shining with curiosity. Real curiosity. She wasn't faking it. Which meant she didn't recognize the envelope. Which meant…

Oh.

"I don't think I can go out this weekend," Adora murmured, stowing the letter in her backpack. "Sorry." Tallstar blinked, then brushed. "Oh, no problem. I um...I...I'm sorry if I read things wrong."

"No, it's okay," Adora assured her quickly. "I...I have to go."

She hurried off before Tallstar could stop her. She tried to get home, but curiosity was burning a hole in her mind, and she had to stop on the middle of the sidewalk, taking the letter out and carefully unfolding it.

Hey Adora—

I've been sitting on this for awhile. I guess that's not a real...But I've seen you hanging out with another girl and—wow that sounds creepy, doesn't it? Not stalking you or anything. We're just in the same lunch period, and I've seen you sitting with her. And she

obviously likes you. Adora, I'm sure you guys will be happy together. But it's kind of weird if some stranger is still sending you notes while you're dating someone. That would be kind of shady. I don't want to just leave you without a goodbye either, though. That's a lot of love. I'm kind of selfish, though, and I don't really want to say goodbye. I guess I'm just afraid that if I do, it won't be real.

But I don't want to be some weird you tell other people about as a cautionary tale or something, so I guess it's time to say goodbye. I hope you're happy. I really do. You deserve it. Adora, I'm sorry. For you.

Adora sat down in the middle of the sidewalk, just staring blankly at the letter. No. No, no, no, no. She wasn't ready to let go. But how could she tell the letter writer? Or was it already too late?

It was hard not to mope that weekend. Adora went through all the letters repeatedly, trying to discern some clue about the letter writer's identity, but there was nothing. *Nothing*. This person had been writing her letters for *three years* and had never given away even one hint about who she was. How?

She ignored Glimmer's and Bow's repeated call and messages and half-heartedly answered her aunts' questions, assuring them she was okay. What was she supposed to do? Tell them the truth? Tell all of them had thoroughly she had messed everything up? They wouldn't understand.

She was going through the letters for a fourth time when someone knocked on her door. She considered hiding them, but it really wasn't worth it.

"Yeah?"

Mara carefully opened the door, peeking in and raising an eyebrow. "You um, you okay? I don't want to say we can practically hear break-up music in here, but…"

Adora sighed, gesturing for her aunt to sit. Mara took a seat at the end of the bed, eyeing the letters carefully.

"It started a few years ago"…

Mara listened as Adora went through the story, leading up to Glimmer's list, and the process of elimination, talking to Tallstar, the last letter, and the realization.

"Man I don't miss high school," Mara said when Adora was done. "We just passed notes back and forth in class asking the other person to check yes or no."

"That's because you're ancient," Adora said with a small, teasing smile. It faded after a moment, though, as her eyes fell back to the letters. "I feel like I ruined things. And I hurt the person writing these letters, and… I hate that."

"Sometimes people get hurt," Mara said, sighing. "You can't save every heart."

"I know." Adora sagged. "And I know I have to just move on. But it's hard. This has been such a big part of my life for so long… this person is important to me, even if I don't return the feelings."

"You have a big heart." Mara reached out to squeeze her shoulder. "It's a burden sometimes."

Adora picked up a letter, staring at it longingly. She knew she couldn't mourn this non-relationship forever. But she'd at least take the weekend.

"Wait, are you *kidding* me?" Glimmer asked, slamming her hands against the table. "But *all* the evidence—"

"It's not her," Adora repeated, taking a bite of her lunch. Bow gave her a sympathetic smile.

I'm sorry, Adora."

"Man, what a coward, though," Glimmer grumbled, crossing her arms. "Just giving up because she sees Adora with someone else?"

It sounds like she was trying to be respectful," Bow said. "Maybe she's not going about it the best way, but she's trying."

If she wants to be with Adora, she should just *do it*. Secret pining is stupid."

Adora thought back over the letters. She didn't think it was cowardly. She thought maybe the person was afraid. Afraid of rejection. Afraid her feelings just wouldn't be returned. Afraid she would get hurt. Adora didn't blame her. It was scary, putting her heart out to the world. She wouldn't have even had the courage to write letters, or keep them up. She didn't want to get hurt either.

The bell rang, and they made their way out of the cafeteria, heading to class. "Maybe you could give Tallstar a chance? I mean, she asked you out, so she must be ~~o~~of!"

Glimmer grunted as she walked into something. It took Adora a moment to realize it was Catra's guitar case. On Catra's back. Glimmer still didn't see who she had walked into, and started to say, "Sorry about — *oh*. Never mind."

Catra huffed, securing her case over her shoulder. "Do you have eyeballs, Sparkles? It's a giant black case, you can't miss it."

It's a *hard*. Can't you figure out your lone sad emo image without carrying around something that'll hurt someone?"

"Oh, go fu—"

"Come on, Wildcat!" Scorpia said cheerfully, wrapping an arm around her shoulders. "Class isn't going to learn itself!"

Glimmer rolled her eyes as Scorpia led Catra away. "I don't know *how* they're friends. Scorpia's so nice and Catra's *so* obnoxious."

A few weeks passed without contact from the letter writer, and Adora was almost ready to throw in the towel. She'd messed this up. She understood. She wasn't going to keep pushing and risk hurting this person more.

But she found herself going through the letters one Saturday for a last look, to see if she could find anything new with fresh eyes. Nothing. She was about to pack the box away and never look at it again when one letter caught her eye. The one from earlier in the school year, with the Taylor Swift lyrics. Adora stared at it for a long moment before taking a picture and opening her text thread with Glimmer.

Adora

Hey, did you know what song this is?

She said it's a cover of a Taylor Swift song

Glimmer

Yeah

I love that cover, it's so pretty

Here

She sent a YouTube link. Adora tapped it and set her phone aside to listen while she packed up. The song opened with a piano playing, then—

"*We were both young when I first saw you*"—

Adora nearly fell off the bed. She grabbed her phone and paused it, staring at the video in disbelief. The lyrics were right there at the

bottom of the video.

No. That was impossible. She was just projecting or something. Misremembering the song Catra had started singing under the bleachers, before Scorpia had interrupted. Right? This wasn't possible. Right?

"I'm going out!" Adora yelled as she hurried out the door, not bothering to wait for a response. Mara and Hope could be mad at her later if they wanted her to stay home.

Adora ran the entire way to Catra's house, cool fall air whipping against her face. Catra only lived about a mile away, but the run felt like it took forever.

She tripped over herself as she came to a halt outside Catra's fault. Her mother Lyra was working on the front garden, probably taking advantage of the last nice days before winter came in. Adora opened her mouth to speak, then realized she didn't know what to say. She hadn't been here or seen Catra's mothers since the beginning of high school. Did they even remember her?

"Oh, Adora!"

Well, that answered that question. Lyra smiled cheerfully at Adora, waving. "Catra's in her room. Unless you're here to be my gardening buddy?"

She was teasing, but there was a hopeful lilt in her tone. Adora smiled a bit. "Not today, sorry."

"No one wants to garden with me." Lyra sighed, but she didn't actually look put out, so Adora assumed it was fine. "If you can get Catra out of her room though, I'll forgive you."

"I'll do my best."

The house hadn't changed much in three years, aside from pictures being swapped around as more were added to the collection. Adora passed through the kitchen on her way to the stairs, and caught sight of an acceptance letter on the fridge, held up by a magnet. It was from *Harvard*. Jesus. She continued on before that scared her away.

Catra's door was closed. Adora hesitated before knocking. "I don't want to garden, Mama," Catra called. Adora almost smiled. She debated telling Catra she wasn't Lyra, or just opening the door. She went with opening the door. Catra was sitting on her bed with her back to the door, guitar in her lap. A new bookshelf had appeared in the last three years, stocked with musical stuff and art supplies. Adora almost immediately zeroed in on the fountain pens scattered across Catra's desk.

"I *know* it's probably the last good gardening day. I promise I'll help you when the season starts again."

Adora coughed. "Um"…

Catra sat up straight, looking over her shoulder, eyes wide. "Oh. Um…hey Adora."

"Hi. Working on something?"

"Nah, just messing around. Got a request?"

Adora bit her lip, then barreled ahead. "How about a Taylor Swift song?"

"Seriously?" Catra scoffed. "I hate Taylor Swift."

"Even if someone makes the song gay?"

There it was – Catra went stiff, pupils narrowing. Adora looked at the fountain pens again, then at the stack of paper set off to the side. She recognized that paper. She'd handled it over and over so many times in just the last couple weeks.

"It's you, isn't it?" Adora asked, voice shaking. Catra looked away, not denying it. But also not confirming it. "Catra—"

"Just let it go, Adora," Catra said, still not looking at her.

"Let it *go*?" Adora said in disbelief. "You're kidding, right?"

"No, I'm not kidding. I don't need to hear that you don't want me. I already know."

"How could you know? You never actually *asked* me!"

"You've been getting cozy with Tallstar for weeks. I'm not blind, you know."

"Are you *sure* about that?" Adora asked. "Because I haven't talked to Tallstar outside of homeroom in nearly a month. Do we look *cozy* to you?"

Catra was quiet for a moment. "The point still stands."

"No, it doesn't!" Adora threw her hands up in frustration. "Did it ever occur to you *ask* me about my feeling instead of just deciding how I feel?"

"Did you ever even *think* it could be me? You've been talking to other girls in our grade. Hell, you talked to *Sonja*, and she definitely didn't fall for whatever fake casual thing you tried to sell."

Adora blushed deeply. "I... I thought that kind of thing would be... I don't know, beneath you. Also *you* stopped talking to *me*. Sorry if it's hard to believe that you'd just cut me off one day after two years of friendship but start leaving *love letters* in my locker."

"I just did what everyone wanted and saved us all a lot of trouble."

"And what does *that* mean?"

"It means your *new friends* didn't like me, Adora! How long was it going to take you to choose them over me? Was I supposed to wait?"

Adora opened and closed her mouth a few times, stunned. "I wasn't going to *choose*. No one ever tried to make me – did Glimmer say something to you?"

"She said a *lot* of things to me," Catra replied bitterly. "I don't know why her insecurities were my problem. But of course you were going to choose them. They're just… *better* than me."

"That's… That's not true," Adora said weakly. Catra snorted.

"Yes it is. They're nice and people like them and they don't *scare* people. Why *wouldn't* you choose them?"

"*You* were my friend first. Why wouldn't I choose you?" Catra looked away, not answering. She really believed this. Adora didn't understand. "Then why the letters?"

Catra shrugged, still not looking at her. "I… I don't know. I missed you, and I thought writing it out would help, but then it felt like… like I was holding a bomb. And I just needed to get rid of it, and everything would be fine. Then I heard you telling Glimmer and Bow about it, and you sounded so *excited* about the idea of a secret admirer. And I thought you'd be disappointed if it was me, so I didn't tell you."

Adora didn't know whether to laugh or cry. "You're the only person I wanted it to be," she finally admitted. Catra snapped around to look at her, eyes wide.

"Really?" Adora nodded. "If you just… feel sorry for me or something "—

Her voice drifted off as Adora crossed the room, took the guitar and set it aside, then took Catra's hands. She pulled her up, and kissed

her without hesitation. Catra looked a little dazed when Adora pulled away.

"Wow," she murmured. Adora giggled before she could stop herself, and then Catra laughed, and then they were both laughing. "So uh… how're you going to break the news to Sparkles?"

"Honestly, I think she'll be more upset about being wrong than she will be about you." Adora squeezed Catra's hands. "Does this mean you'd be willing to, you know…" She swung their arms between them. "Be with me at school?"

"Gee, I don't know. Do I want to be the star football player's girlfriend? Sounds like such a burden…"

Adora rolled her eyes, giving Catra a light shove. "Wait, were you going to tell me under the bleachers that day? You started singing that song…"

Catra blushed, looking down. "Yeah. It was so stupid, but I thought it was a good idea. Scorpia felt *so* bad about interrupting. She apologized the entire way home."

Well that explained the look she gave Adora. "Wait, Scorpia knows?"

Catra raised a hand, waving it back and forth. "She knows *some* things. She and Entrapta both suck at keeping secrets, so I don't tell them too much. She knew I was working on that song for you, though. I guess she thought she'd interrupted my big confession. Which, can you imagine if I'd *planned* that? Worst confession plan ever."

Adora thought it was kind of sweet, actually. Catra had been sitting under the bleachers, playing guitar like something out of a movie. Or a dream.

This entire thing felt like a great dream. And Adora didn't want to wake up.

"*What?*"

Conversation in the cafeteria faltered slightly as Glimmer's shriek echoed through the air. Heads started turning to look at their table, including Catra's. Adora resisted the urge to slide down in her seat.

"Are you *kidding me*?!" Glimmer demanded in a slightly quieter voice. "Is this some sick joke?"

"No." Adora sat up straighter, expression set. "Which reminds me, did you say something to make her feel bad about herself?"

"Is she *capable* of that?" Glimmer scoffed. "Her ego is huge."

She was a really good actress, actually. But Adora didn't want to get into that debate. "You didn't answer my question."

Glimmer scrubbed her eyes for a moment, thinking. "Nothing like… about you. But yeah, I told her she's an unbearable, egotistical know it all and I didn't understand how anyone could deal with her."

"Okay, well, you're not allowed to say anything like that to her." Glimmer opened her mouth to protest. "Nope! She's my girlfriend, you have to at least be civil with her. And yes, I told her the same thing about you."

"*Fine*," Glimmer grumbled, pouting. Bow patted her head, and shot Adora a smile.

"How does it feel to say girlfriend?"

Amazing, actually. Adora couldn't stop the giddy smile that turned into a small laugh. "Oh, young love." Bow smiled a dreamy smile. "It's so sweet."

"What, are we old now?" Glimmer asked, raising an eyebrow.

"Are you going to ask her to the Winter Fest dance? We can double date!"

Adora hadn't really thought about it, but the idea of proposing a double date with Glimmer and Bow definitely made her laugh. Catra hated Glimmer just as much as Glimmer hated Catra. Adora was sure her reaction would be hilarious and colorful.

Catra opened her locker, and blinked in surprise when an envelope fell out. "Oooooh, what's that?" Scorpia asked.

"No idea." Catra knelt to grab it. Her name was scrawled across the front in familiar writing. She carefully opened the envelope and pulled out the letter.

Hey Catra—

I'm sorry this is kind of plain, I'm not artistic like you are. Maybe you could teach me how to use fountain pens?

Also, will you go to the Winter Fest Dance with me? Glimmer and Bow are trying to double date. We, Bow wants to double date. Glimmer can't say anything nice, so she isn't saying anything at all.

—Adora

Catra couldn't stop the small, stupid smile that pulled at her lips. "Aaaawww, Wildcat." Scorpia gave her a starry-eyed look. "I'm so happy for you."

"Oh. shut up," Catra muttered, still smiling, as she shoved the letter in her bag and turned away.

Somehow, amazingly, there was a letter in Adora's locker the next morning. How early did Catra get here?

Hey Adora—

Yes, I teach you how to use fountain pens. And dance sounds good, going with your friend and story, though?

Adora smiled, rolling her eyes. She had, of course, gone all out with the short letter, using her best penmanship and probably most beautiful fountain pen. Show off.

"*Darling, won't you save me, they're trying to tell me how to feel. This love is difficult, but it's real…*"

Someday Adora would hear the full song. But today was not that day. Catra stopped playing abruptly, looking over her shoulder as some students came out of the locker room.

"Why do you bring it to school if you don't want anyone else to hear you?"

"I don't care if they hear me. I care if they hear me playing Taylor fucking Swift. Do you know how embarrassing that is? People are going to think I'm some weird sap or something."

"You *are*." Adora poked her knee, smiling. "You found a gay version of a song you hate and learned it just to serenade me. That's *so* sappy."

"Shut *up*." Catra batted her hand away. "I'm never playing this again."

"Even I put on the best puppy eyes and ask really nicely?"

"Your puppy eyes can't hurt me. My heart is made of stone."

Adora almost cracked and laughed at that. Catra was the single softest person she knew aside from maybe Bow and Scorpia. *Heart and ofstone*. Okay.

"One more time. If you get interrupted again, I wont ask anymore. But I've *never* heard this entire song in full." She pouted. "Pleeeeeeeeeeease?"

It was easy to crack Catra's stone heart. She sighed, strumming the guitar strings. "*Fine*."

Adora beamed, crossing her legs and preparing to be the most supportive one-person audience ever.

"*We were both young when I first saw you.*"

End Notes

Why is Glimmer so mean to Catra?
Catra is also extremely mean to Glimmer . We just don't see it here. They'll get over it eventually.

Gay Taylor Swift song: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=O2W8TGSBE

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